

South Africa



A country ruled by a white minority through an oppressive system of apartheid until 1993.

600s After migrating slowly south, Bantu-speaking peoples settle in today's Transvaal, Natal, and Eastern Cape; Khoisan-speaking herders and hunter-gatherers live in the rest of the country.

1652 The Dutch East India Company establishes a provisioning station at Table Bay in the Cape, the first white settlement.

1779 Competition for grazing and arable land between the Dutch and the Xhosa develops into a series of frontier wars that continue for the next century.

1795 British first take the Cape; after a further period of Dutch rule (1803–06), the UK formally acquires the colony in 1814.

1835 Land-hungry Boer settlers, frustrated by Xhosa resistance and resenting British domination, begin their Great Trek north. Despite fierce battles with the Zulus and others, they expand white occupation into what is now the Transvaal, Natal, and Orange Free State.

1852 The Transvaal and, in 1854, the Orange Free State both gain their independence. Natal (proclaimed a colony in 1843) remains under British rule and is populated by British settlers.

1871 Four years after the discovery of diamonds, the UK annexes the diamond fields. This is followed in 1877 by the annexation of the Transvaal with its gold fields. Exploitation of diamonds and gold leads to economic boom and development of the migrant labor system, with African areas becoming "labor reservoirs."

1880–81 In the First South African (Boer) War, the Boers rise in revolt and defeat the British at Majuba Hill in 1881, winning back their independence. The British also fight and defeat the Zulus, but suffer a huge defeat at Isandlwana in 1879.

1896 Jameson Raid: a mounted column of British South Africa Company troops are captured by Boer forces.

1899–1902 Second South African (Boer) War is launched by Boer leader Paul Kruger with attacks on Natal and Cape Colony. After initial Boer successes the Boer capital, Pretoria, is captured in June 1900 and Boer guerrilla resistance is broken down. British keep Boer civilians in concentration camps.

1902 Treaty of Vereeniging incorporates Transvaal and Orange Free State once again into the British Empire.

1910 Union of South Africa set up; white monopoly of power is formalized.

1912 African National Congress (ANC) is formed.



The Boers

Descendants of the Dutch colonists, the Boers were hardy farmers and tough fighters, maintaining their independence until overcome by the British in 1902. This picture, taken in 1910, shows the wagons they used for defense if attacked.

1948 National Party (NP) takes power; apartheid segregationist policy introduced.

1958–66 Hendrik Verwoerd prime minister: "Grand Apartheid" policy is implemented.

1959 Pan Africanist Congress (PAC) is formed.

1960 Sharpeville massacre: police shoot demonstrators protesting against the pass laws; ANC and PAC banned.

1961 South Africa becomes a republic and leaves the Commonwealth.

1964 ANC leader Nelson Mandela jailed.

1976 Soweto uprisings by black students; hundreds killed.

1978 P. W. Botha in office.

1984 New constitution: Indians and blacks get some representation.

1985 State of emergency introduced.

1989 F. W. De Klerk replaces Botha as president.

1990 De Klerk legalizes ANC and PAC and frees Nelson Mandela.

1990–93 International sanctions gradually withdrawn.

1991 Convention for a Democratic South Africa (CODESA) starts work.

1993 Mandela and De Klerk win Nobel Peace Prize as apartheid is peacefully dismantled.

1994 Multi-racial elections won by the ANC; Mandela is elected president.

1998 Truth and Reconciliation Report condemns both apartheid crimes and ANC excesses.

1999 ANC election victory; Thabo Mbeki succeeds Mandela as president.

2002 World summit on sustainable development held in Johannesburg. Court orders the government to provide anti-AIDS drugs at all hospitals.

2004 ANC wins over two-thirds of the vote in elections; Mbeki is reelected.

2006 Ex-deputy president Jacob Zuma is acquitted on rape charges and reinstated as deputy leader of the ANC.

2008 A wave of anti-foreigner violence sweeps country, directed at Zimbabweans, Malawians, and Mozambicans. Many die. Thabo Mbeki is forced to resign as president over claims he interfered in corruption case against Jacob Zuma.

2009 Jacob Zuma is elected president.

2010 South Africa hosts the soccer World Cup.

«434–35 Civil Rights
«454–55 Apartheid and Beyond

Swaziland



A landlocked kingdom bordered on three sides by South Africa, on whom it is largely dependent.

1902 British protectorate established.

1968 Independence from UK.

1973 King Sobhuza bans political activity.

1978 New constitution confirms king's executive and legislative control.

1982 King Sobhuza dies. Queen Mother becomes regent for Prince Makhosetive. Power struggle between modernists and traditionalists in royal Dlamini clan.

1986 Makhosetive crowned King Mswati III at the age of 18.

1992 Limited electoral reforms, although political parties are still banned.

2002 Mass pro-democracy protests.

2005 The king signs a new constitution that enshrines human rights. The document has taken eight years to draft.

2008 Elections are boycotted by the opposition. An attempted bomb attack is blamed on them and the leader of the Pudemo party is detained.

Lesotho



A mountainous and landlocked monarchy entirely surrounded by South Africa.

1868 British protectorate established after Moshoeshoe I is forced to cede fertile areas to Boers. After administration by Cape Colony between 1871–83, Britain resumes direct responsibility.

1884 Becomes the British Crown Colony of Basutoland.

1966 Independent kingdom.

1986 Military coup.

1990 King Moshoeshoe II exiled; his son installed as Letsie III.

1993 Free elections: Moshoeshoe II returns in 1994 and is restored as king.

1996 Letsie III succeeds to throne.

1998 New Lesotho Congress for Democracy wins polls. South Africa intervenes after coup attempt, and reconciles king and parties.

2004 Prime minister Mosisili appeals for food aid. Hundreds of thousands face shortages after three-year drought.

2007 General strike called by opposition.

DECISIVE MOMENT

THE ARRIVAL OF THE DUTCH, 1652

The arrival of Jan van Riebeeck, five ships (one shown here), and about 90 people in Table Bay on April 6, 1652, had a profound impact on southern Africa. The colonists at first set up a provisioning station for Dutch East India Company ships, but subsequently ventured inland to farm the rich pastures. By the end of the 18th century, Cape Colony was home to the largest concentration of Europeans in Africa. The arrival of the British in 1795, however, changed the situation, as the Dutch were now the colonized and felt their Presbyterian culture to be under threat.

